



MOD FAN OFFICIAL PRESENTS

FAN ARTIST DO'S AND DON'TS

How to create fan art that brands can approve,
license, and celebrate

A Creator-Friendly Guide | 2026



WHY THIS GUIDE EXISTS



FAN ART IS POWERFUL

It connects communities, celebrates beloved characters, and gives artists a way to express passion while building skills and careers.



BRANDS NEED PROTECTION

Characters, logos, and worlds represent years of investment. Brands must protect their IP while still valuing creative community energy.



OPEN OPPORTUNITIES

These guidelines help you create original, brand-safe artwork with the best chance of being approved and officially licensed.



The goal is simple: help you create amazing fan art that brands love, fans want, and everyone can celebrate safely. These guidelines are practical, educational, and protective — not legal advice.

[Always review the individual campaign brief](#) — it always takes priority over these general guidelines. Every campaign and IP holder may have specific rules beyond what is covered here.





THE CORE PRINCIPLE

Create original work inspired by the approved IP, but do not copy, misuse, misrepresent, or combine protected assets in ways the brand has not approved.

Your artwork should come from your own imagination, skill, and interpretation while respecting the boundaries that protect the brand's characters, reputation, and commercial rights.

ORIGINALITY IS YOUR GREATEST ASSET



THE QUICK DO'S

Creator-friendly rules to help your art get approved

- ✓ **Create original artwork** in your own unique style
- ✓ **Follow the campaign brief** and use approved characters
- ✓ **Create commercially usable artwork** if selected
- ✓ **Keep files clean, layered, and high resolution**
- ✓ **Design with merchandise production** in mind from the start
- ✓ **Disclose any AI assistance** if you use it
- ✓ **Submit clean, original work** — every element yours
- ✓ **Respect the brand's tone, audience, and values**

★ When you create something genuinely new that honors the source material, everyone benefits: you build your portfolio, the brand gains fresh creative energy, and fans get artwork they love.





THE QUICK DON'TS

Common mistakes that lead to rejection or legal risk

- ✗ **Do not copy or trace** official artwork or screenshots
- ✗ **Do not use brand logos** unless explicitly allowed
- ✗ **Do not use another artist's work** — plagiarism is unacceptable
- ✗ **Do not mix IPs** or create crossovers without approval
- ✗ **Do not include offensive, hateful, or explicit content**
- ✗ **Do not sell submitted work** elsewhere before approval
- ✗ **Do not use copyrighted fonts** or assets without rights
- ✗ **Do not imply official endorsement** before it's real



These rules aren't here to limit your creativity — they protect you, protect brands, and significantly increase your chance of getting officially licensed and paid for your work.





ORIGINALITY IS WHAT GETS LICENSED

Brands want fresh interpretations — not copied screenshots

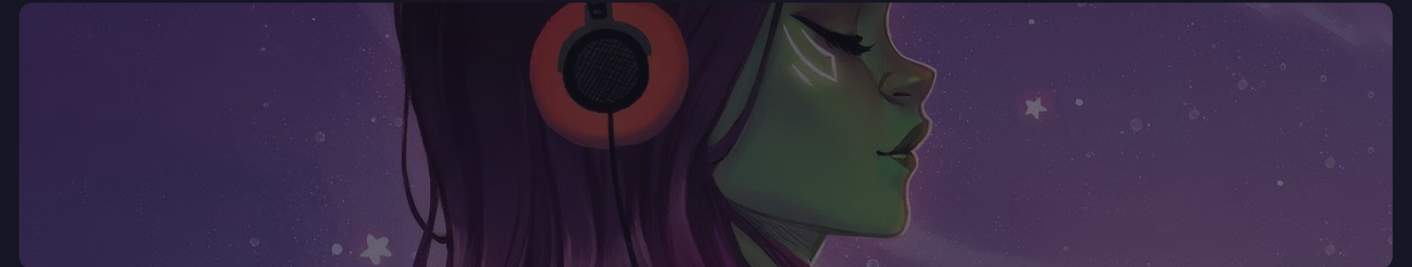
WHAT GETS REJECTED

- ✗ Tracing screenshots or official artwork
- ✗ Recreating movie posters or promo images
- ✗ Copying the same poses and compositions
- ✗ Redrawn official art in a different medium



WHAT GETS APPROVED

- ✓ New original scenes and character moments
- ✓ Your unique artistic style and interpretation
- ✓ Fresh environments and unexplored situations
- ✓ Art that shows your creative vision and skill



Original compositions demonstrate your skill and significantly reduce legal risk. When SEGA reviews Hatsune Miku submissions, original illustrations receive strong consideration while copies of promotional materials are disqualified.



FOLLOW THE CAMPAIGN BRIEF

THE CAMPAIGN BRIEF ALWAYS COMES FIRST

Each MOD campaign provides specific guidance about which **characters, themes, styles,** and **product types** are being sought.

The brief exists because the brand has identified a specific creative need. Submitting artwork that ignores these directions wastes your time and reduces your chance of approval.

EXAMPLES

- ✗ If the brief asks for **chibi stickers**, a dramatic realistic battle scene won't fit the campaign.
- ✗ If the brief specifies **certain characters only**, don't add unauthorized characters from the same universe.
- ✓ Read the brief **before you start drawing** to ensure your concept aligns with what the brand needs.



Stick to the characters, worlds, and elements specifically identified in the campaign brief. Crossovers and mashups are fun for personal projects but create significant licensing complexity.



COMMON INFRINGEMENT RISKS

Understanding these risks helps you make smarter creative decisions

COPYRIGHT

Copying or closely reproducing protected creative works without permission

TRADEMARK

Using brand names, logos, or distinctive symbols without authorization

RIGHT OF PUBLICITY

Using real people's names, images, or likenesses without their consent

FALSE ENDORSEMENT

Creating the impression your art is officially affiliated with or endorsed by the brand

PLAGIARISM

Presenting another artist's work or ideas as your own

UNAUTHORIZED USE

Selling merchandise or using IP in commercial activities without a license

THIRD-PARTY ASSETS

Using unlicensed fonts, textures, stock images, or 3D models in your work

AI SIMILARITY RISKS

AI outputs that inadvertently reproduce copyrighted compositions or artwork



BRAND APPROVAL CHECKLIST

What brands look for during the review process

ORIGINALITY

Fresh ideas, not rehashes



BRAND FIT

Belongs in the universe



AUDIENCE FIT

Right tone for the demographic



COMMERCIAL USE

Works on products fans want



LEGAL SAFETY

No infringement risk



PRODUCTION QUALITY

Clean, professional execution



MARKETING POTENTIAL

Shareable and exciting



CHARACTER ACCURACY

Shows you know the source

The most successful fan art offers something **new** while remaining true to the source. Stylized approaches, chibi versions, humorous situations, and alternative art styles can all succeed when they bring fresh creative energy.



DESIGNING FOR MERCHANDISE

Think about product use from the very beginning



APPAREL

Design for center chest 6-10 inches. Avoid fine details that won't print clearly on fabric.



STICKERS

Bold outlines, reads clearly at 2-4 inches. Clean cut lines, avoid overly complex shapes.



PRINTS & POSTERS

Higher resolution acceptable. Consider standard frame sizes and aspect ratios.



PHONE CASES

Avoid edge wraps unless specified. Keep key elements away from camera cutouts.



PINS & COLLECTIBLES

Simplified designs work best. Limit color palette, avoid tiny details at small scale.

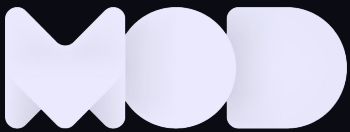


ACRYLIC CHARMS

Bold shapes that read at small scale. Simple, recognizable silhouettes work best.



The most commercially valuable designs work across multiple product types. Consider scalability early — a bold graphic that looks great on a t-shirt should also work as a sticker, phone case, or poster.



FILE QUALITY MATTERS

Technical requirements for production-ready submissions



300 DPI MINIMUM

Minimum resolution for all print projects



TRANSPARENT PNGS

Clean transparent backgrounds for stickers, apparel



LAYERED SOURCE FILES

PSD, AI, Procreate, or Clip Studio files



READABLE TEXT

Correct spelling and character details



CLEAN CUT LINES

Essential for sticker and die-cut products



NO WATERMARKS

Submit clean final artwork for evaluation

RESOLUTION BY PRODUCT TYPE

Product Type	Resolution	Preferred Format
Apparel (DTG)	300 DPI, 10-12 inches wide	PNG (transparent), sRGB
Stickers	300 DPI, designed at final size	PNG with transparent background
Art Prints	300 DPI, full bleed if possible	TIFF, high-quality PNG



AI-ASSISTED ARTWORK

AI policies vary by brand — always check the campaign brief



Some brands prohibit AI entirely. Others allow limited use. **Always check the specific campaign brief.**

DO

- ✓ Use AI for ideation and mood boards
- ✓ Disclose any AI assistance in your submission
- ✓ Apply substantial creative transformation to AI outputs
- ✓ Use your own creative prompts and direction
- ✓ Review AI outputs carefully for quality and originality

DON'T

- ✗ Use AI to copy a specific artist's style
- ✗ Submit raw AI output without significant human modification
- ✗ Hide AI use or represent AI output as fully hand-created
- ✗ Use prompts designed to replicate copyrighted works
- ✗ Assume AI output is automatically safe from infringement



Human creativity, editing, and originality matter most. Brands want to ensure AI-assisted work meets the same quality and originality standards as fully human-created art.



ALLOWED VS NOT ALLOWED

✓ ALLOWED

- ✓ **Original chibi version** of an approved character
- ✓ **New character moment** not shown in the source material
- ✓ **Stylized interpretation** in your unique artistic voice
- ✓ **Merch-ready sticker design** with clean lines and bold shapes
- ✓ **Characters as animals** in a distinct style from official art
- ✓ **Stylized portrait** avoiding actor's specific facial features

✗ NOT ALLOWED

- ✗ **Traced screenshot** or poster recreation
- ✗ **Official logo** placed on a shirt design
- ✗ **Crossover** with another franchise
- ✗ **Copied pose** from another fan artist's work
- ✗ **Celebrity likeness** without proper approval
- ✗ **Cultural or religious symbols** used without understanding



SUBMISSION CHECKLIST

Final review before uploading your artwork

ORIGINALITY

Did I create this myself from start to finish?

Did I avoid tracing, copying, or closely reproducing official art?

Is every element my own original creation?

Do I have full rights to license this artwork?

Have I kept source files and process documentation?

BRAND COMPLIANCE

Did I follow the campaign brief precisely?

Did I avoid logos and unapproved IP?

Is the content appropriate for the brand's audience?

Does it respect the brand's tone and values?

Does it avoid implying official endorsement?

TECHNICAL & LEGAL

Is it high resolution (300 DPI)?

Did I disclose any AI assistance?

Is it ready for the intended merchandise type?

Have I avoided selling it elsewhere?

Are all fonts and assets properly licensed?

A THOROUGH SELF-REVIEW DRAMATICALLY IMPROVES YOUR CHANCE OF APPROVAL



MOD FAN OFFICIAL

LET'S MAKE FAN ART OFFICIAL

MOD Fan Official exists to help fan artists get **seen, approved, licensed, and paid.**



REVIEW THE BRIEF



CREATE ORIGINAL WORK



SUBMIT WITH CONFIDENCE

Your passion + your originality = officially licensed art

We can't wait to see what you create.